possible, but an evacuation of foreign troops has been promised by the "Big Three".

It is difficult to exaggerate the cultural and economic gulf between the various social levels of a Middle Eastern country, such as Iran or Egypt. At one extreme there is a debased poverty, an illiteracy and a limited local horizon reflecting a manner of life little removed from that of the meanest serf of the Pharaohs. At the other extreme there is luxury, higher education in the great universities of Europe, and -- for the rich Egyptians -- a cosmopolitan cycle of winters in Egypt and summers in the cooler climate of northern Europe. This internal social gulf is no greater, however, than the gulf between various Middle Eastern communities. From Tel Aviv (the pride of Palestine Jewry) to Riyad (King Ibn Saud's "home town") is no more than 1,000 miles as the crow flies, but -- despite Ibn Saud's armored cars and Rolls Royce limousines -- the two communities are at least three centuries apart in history.

It used to be popular to say that the Middle East was "in transition". But a transition, even if it need not involve a well-defined starting point, means at least a definable goal. In the 1920's, it was possible to believe that such a goal was accepted by almost all Middle Eastern societies: popular education, political democracy, freedom from foreign rule, industrialization, and transformation of the traditional cultural heritage of Islam under the impact of Western rationalism and science. In the middle of the 1940's, only one of these objectives commands undivided support: freedom from foreign rule. For the rest, the Middle East is in confusion rather than in transition. It has given up its traditional standards and has found no common compelling allegiances in others.